“I’ll get him,” said Johanna, taking her silence for assent.

She raised her hand, but it was too late. Johanna had gone. Why not tell him? Once she was well, she would go. He would have to let her. Now, she knew his secret. *There will be no trace that I was in the Gestapo.* She could do to him what he did to her.

“Hello?” There was something different about his voice. She turned to the door. Johanna held his arm, guiding him. Was something wrong?

“Hello, Hans,” she said calmly.

“I’m glad you’re talking. I was so worried.” He turned. “Where’s the chair?”

“Let me bring it closer to the bed,” Johanna said. “There you go. Here’s your cane. Is there anything else you need? I’ll be in the next room. Just call.”

“What’s happened?” Rose sat up a little.

“He lost his sight when he went through the fire and smoke to get you out.”

Rose looked down at her arms, wrapped in thin white gauze.

“Yes, and legs both badly burned.” Johanna sighed. “The doctor said it was a miracle you survived, and if it had been minutes later the smoke would have killed you.”

A throbbing deep in Rose’s throat. She looked at him. His eyes were no longer blue but covered by a milky film. His gaze drifted, unable to meet her own, and ribbed burn scars marked his eyelids.

“I’m sorry you were hurt,” she said. “I didn’t know.”

“All that matters is that you’re safe.” He sobbed. “I thought I’d lost you.”

You almost did. She had been so close. But her timing was off. Too late. Why hadn’t she gone earlier?

He leaned forward, gently reaching out his hand until he found the ring on her finger. “You’re everything to me. I couldn’t survive without you.”

Keep a good heart. Her sister’s mantra and her mother’s words came to her. Even when everything is lost? *Yes*, a voice deep inside answered. Rose glanced at the bandages on her legs and arms, and then at his hand on her ring finger. She understood that of all the healing that awaited her in the months and years ahead, the physical wounds would be the easiest to mend. He’d done terrible things that she could never forgive, but nor could she